Ryan McWay

Teaching Statement

Contact Information

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Teaching Goal

My goal is to build classrooms where students are engaged, supported, and able to retain what they learn. I pursue this by turning lecture material into learning activities—games, experiments, and applied projects—that raise the opportunity cost of distraction for a student body that is often more occupied by their phones than by a lecture. I have developed these skills as the instructor of record for five courses at Hamline University, Macalester College, and the University of Minnesota, and as a teaching assistant for eleven courses spanning the principles level through graduate econometrics. I am prepared to teach microeconomics, econometrics, data analysis, and data mining, as well as courses in development, environmental, and behavioral economics.

Teaching Experience

Instructor

QMBE 3740	Data Mining	Bachelors	Hamline University	2026
ECON 294-05	Econ. of Sustainable Development	Bachelors	Macalester College	2026
ECON 3750	Behavioral & Exp. Economics	Bachelors	Hamline University	2025
APEC 1201	App. of Excel in Econ. and Mgmt.	Bachelors	University of Minnesota	2024
————	Applied Economics Math Review	Doctoral	University of Minnesota	2023

Teaching Assistant

APEC 3611	Env. and Nat. Res. Economics	Bachelors	University of Minnesota	2026
APEC 1101	Principles of Microeconomics	Bachelors	University of Minnesota	2025
FW 8452	Conservation Biology	Doctoral	University of Minnesota	2025
APEC 5032	Economic Data Analysis	Masters	University of Minnesota	2024
APEC 3003	Intro. to Applied Econometrics	Bachelors	University of Minnesota	2023
ECON 620	Graduate Econometrics	Masters	University of San Francisco	2020
ECON 427	Applied Econometrics Capstone	Bachelors	University of San Francisco	2020
ECON 312	Intermediate Macroeconomics	Bachelors	University of San Francisco	2020
ECON 111	Principles of Microeconomics	Bachelors	University of San Francisco	2020
ECON 615	Mathematics for Economists	Masters	University of San Francisco	2019
ECON 112	Principles of Macroeconomics	Bachelors	University of San Francisco	2019

Teaching Philosophy

My philosophy is to limit barriers to learning and to increase retention. Three principles guide how I design a course.

Make students active participants. Passive lecture competes poorly with a cellphone. I therefore pair short lectures with in-class activities where students must do something with the idea. In *Behavioral and Experimental Economics*, students played in-class games that illustrated each concept and then designed and ran their own behavioral experiments as a course project. Students told me the lectures prepared them for quizzes, that the games made learning fun, and that the project was a real chance to try out experiments themselves.

Repeat the foundations in new contexts. I design course material to return to core ideas each time new material is introduced, so students re-evaluate the tenets of the field through repeated exposure in varied settings. I deliver this through a mix of in-person and online media so that students with different schedules, backgrounds, and learning preferences can all engage. In *Economics of Sustainable Development*, I designed the course to

re-evaluate the strong and weak definitions of sustainability with applications to natural resources, population dynamics, economic inequality, pollution externalities, climate change, and conservation.

Be a welcoming and responsive instructor. Students learn more when they feel comfortable asking questions. I encourage in-class questions and answer emails promptly and thoroughly, listen carefully when students bring technical problems, and treat every student fairly. In *Applications of Excel in Economics and Management*, where software troubles can derail a student's progress with foundational data analysis skills, this responsiveness mattered most. Student feedback across my courses consistently highlights that I am approachable, quick to respond, and clear in my explanations.

Student Testimonials

Below are some selected comments from end-of-semester course evaluations reflecting my quality of teaching.

- **Economics of Sustainable Development (ECON 294-05), Macalester College**
  - "One of if not the best class I have taken so far at macalester."
  - "He was always super friendly and welcoming."
  - "Ryan was extremely quick at responding to any concerns I had."
  - "Really good at explaining stuff and always gave satisfactory responses to in class questions and emails."
- **Behavioral and Experimental Economics (ECON 3750-1/MKTG 3755-1), Hamline University**
  - "The project was an awesome chance to try out the behavioral experiments."
  - "The lectures helped with quizzes and the games made it a fun learning experience."
- **Applications of Excel in Economics and Management (APEC 1201), University of Minnesota**
  - "Ryan seems to be really professional with all he do, he has a lot of knowledge about this kind of classes, and also he is a really good teacher."
  - "Ryan was a very active listener and was there to be understanding of technical problems I was having. He answered all of my questions and treated everyone fairly."

Synergistic Activities (Service)

1. **Diversity, Equity and Inclusion.** I have engaged with the promotion of diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) both within and outside my academic institutions to advance student diversity and increase inclusion in the classroom. Previously, I was a student representative on the DEI Committee for the University of Minnesota's Institute for Social Research and Data Innovation (ISRDI), and I currently sit on the Inclusive Excellence (IE) committee as a student representative for the Applied Economics department. In both roles, I created support tools for students and advocated on their behalf. Additionally, I have acted as a mentor through the GAIN Network to improve PhD applications for prospective students from Sub-Saharan Africa.

2. **Organizing Student Research.** I actively promote student research. In my PhD program, I organized the bi-weekly APEC student seminar highlighting ongoing student work and developed a bi-weekly APEC skills workshop covering statistical, technical, and professional skills missing from our core curriculum. I also organize the PhD Economics Virtual Seminar (PhD-EVS), which hosts weekly presentations by PhD students and increases dialogue across departments.